

Say "I Do" to Paying Double:

The Hidden Economics of the Great Indian Wedding



It started as an idle experiment. A friend of mine, hunting for a photographer ahead of her wedding, rang up five studios in Gurugram and asked for a quote on a couple's portrait session. The numbers came back tight and unremarkable between ₹12,000 and ₹18,000. A week later, she called the very same studios again. Same camera, same editing style, same photographer on the line. The only change was one sentence: "Actually, this is for my wedding" and the quotes this time landed anywhere between ₹90,000 and a staggering ₹1,50,000.

Ask around and you will hear a version of this story from almost anyone who has planned a wedding in India. Banquet halls quote one rate for a birthday party and a noticeably higher one the moment 'shaadi' enters the conversation. Nothing about the hall, the food, or the lighting has changed. Only a word has. And that, it turns out, is precisely the point.

This is not a story about greedy vendors. It is a rather elegant, if slightly uncomfortable, demonstration of three ideas at the heart of any introductory microeconomics course:

willingness to pay, price discrimination, and elasticity of demand. Together, they explain why a single word can quietly double a bill.

The Price of a Promise

Economists define willingness to pay, or WTP, as the maximum a buyer would hand over rather than walk away empty-handed. Crucially, willingness to pay is not dictated by what a good cost to produce a camera does not get pricier to operate on a wedding day. It is dictated by circumstance: how much the buyer stands to lose by not paying, and how little room they have to negotiate.

For a firm to profit from this, though, it needs a way to tell which customers have a high willingness to pay and which have a low one, and charge them accordingly and practice textbooks call this price discrimination. No vendor can peer into a client's bank balance or emotional state, so they look instead for a reliable signal, a proxy that sorts customers without the customers being able to simply pretend otherwise.

The word 'wedding' performs that sorting function almost perfectly. It signals that the client has budgeted heavily for one irreplaceable day, that the date and venue are already locked in, and that walking away over a fee is emotionally and logistically costly. None of that is true of a casual couple's shoot, which can be rescheduled or cancelled without consequence.

Why the Market Gets Away With It

The reason this pricing works so cleanly brings in the third idea: elasticity of demand. Demand

is elastic when a price rise sends buyers looking elsewhere; it is inelastic when buyers keep buying regardless, because there is nowhere else to go.

A birthday party is textbook elastic demand and its quote is too high, so you shift the date or book a smaller hall down the road. A wedding behaves differently. The date is often fixed months ahead by astrologers and relatives flying in from three continents. There is no real substitute for a cheaper wedding photographer, the way there is for a soft drink, because the transaction cannot be repeated and there is no second wedding day to shop around for. Inelastic demand is exactly the condition under which raising prices barely dents how much is sold, which is why vendors lean on it so readily.

Line the two ideas up and the logic becomes almost mechanical i.e. the word 'wedding' filters customers into a high willingness to pay, low-elasticity bracket, and the market responds exactly as price theory predicts that charging this bracket more, not because the product changed, but because the buyer's leverage did.

A Pattern, Not an Exception

Photography is only the most visible example. Bridal outfits routinely cost three to four times as much as near-identical pieces sold as party wear. Makeup artists maintain a separate, higher bridal package even when the products and technique are unchanged from an evening look. Caterers, too, have been known to revise their quote the moment 'shaadi ka khaana' replaces corporate lunch. Wedding forums online are full of near-identical anecdotes, suggesting this is less a rogue vendor's trick than an industry wide norm.

Interestingly, a quiet counter-trend has emerged among more economically literate couples: booking services as a pre-wedding shoot

specifically to dodge the higher tier the word 'wedding' would trigger. That, too, is economics in action where buyers respond rationally once they decode the very signal being used against them.

The Takeaway

The so-called wedding premium is a reminder that prices rarely track cost alone. They track belief about a market's read of what a buyer can bear, and how little choice that buyer has to refuse. Every time a single word changes a quote, someone on the other end of the phone has, whether they know it or not, correctly estimated your elasticity of demand. So the next time a vendor's price quietly doubles the moment you mention the big day, know this: you are not paying for a sharper camera or a finer shade of lipstick. You are paying, for one day, the price of having nowhere else to go.

References:

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AI Declaration-

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